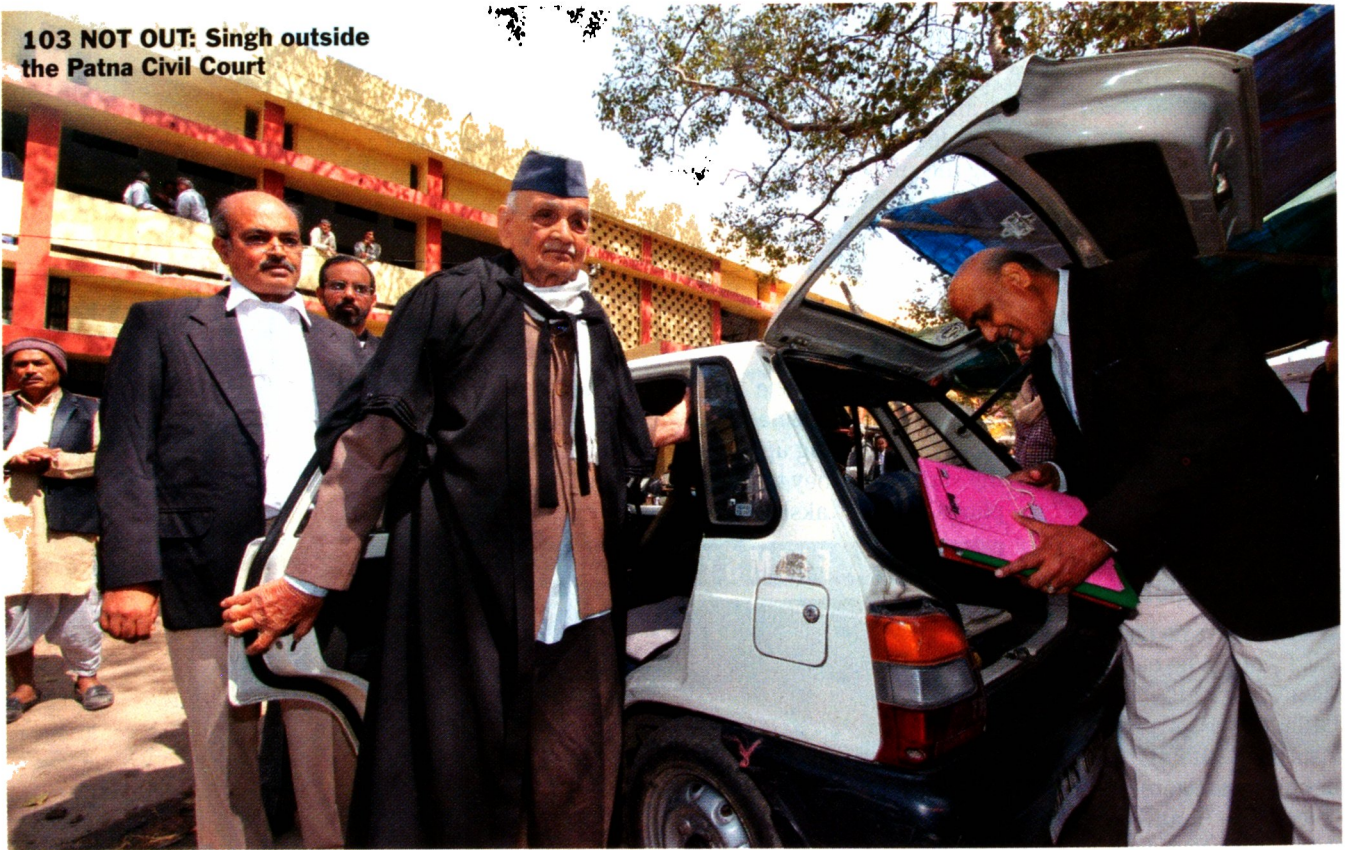


103 NOT OUT: Singh outside the Patna Civil Court



Advocating Indomitability

A 103-year-old patriarch doesn't let age come in the way of actively practising law

■ **By Amitabh Srivastava**

Every morning, when the clock strikes half past eight, advocate Bajrang Bahadur Singh begins his day by going through a few law books at home. After a light breakfast, he is seated in his Maruti 800, which also doubles as his office for the next six hours. Parked under a tree at Patna civil court, Singh imparts advice to fellow lawyers, dictates briefs to assistants and deliberates with his clients. This may sound like the usual routine for any lawyer, but this is a routine that Singh has been following since September 10, 1934, the day he joined the bar. Today, at 103 years of age, Singh is perhaps the oldest practising lawyer in the country.

Age is no deterrent to this indefatigable grand old man of the Patna legal fraternity. Says Singh, "I am not in the best of physical health. Today, I need to be helped to the first floor court room whenever I have to argue a case there. But, practising is fun for me. I love it."

He needs no visiting card, does not carry a mobile phone and seldom takes calls personally. But that does not stop him from being surrounded by clients at any given time. With two of his sons, Virendra Bahadur Singh and Shailendra Bahadur Singh, he handles five to six cases every month.



His third son, Kundan Bahadur Singh, is a Supreme Court lawyer. His eyesight is weak which makes it difficult for him to read and write as many briefs as he used to. So he makes his juniors and his sons read out law books and take dictation. According to Shailendra, his father's presence is all the more important during appeal arguments.

Says Shailendra, "He makes six to seven personal appearances in court every month."

Singh was born in 1905 in Simri village of Patna district. Incidentally, he began his career as a criminal lawyer assisting noted barrister, Malik Mahmood. He continued as a criminal lawyer for four years before switching over to civil matters. In seven-and-a-half decades, he has been felicitated on several occasions, but the award from the senior citizens' forum in Patna is the one he treasures most.

Singh says his success story would be incomplete without a mention of his wife of 70 years, Kunti Devi. Many ask how he has managed to stay enthusiastic and active despite his old age. According to Singh, a disciplined life style and a vegetarian diet are two factors that have kept him going. He believes the rigorous regimen that he followed in his youth has helped him stay fit and mentally agile. Clearly, age is no bar to being a member of the bar in India. ■